Theologizing Terrorism

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Contemporary discussions of jihadist movements often find themselves compelled to take a clear stance on the extent to which Islamic ideologies can offer to explain and mobilize violence. On one side are accounts that treat such violence as fundamentally rooted in Islamic ideology. As Reza Aslan, an Iranian-American sociologist, writes in his book *No god but God*, scholars such as Bernard Lewis and Max Weber have perpetuated the "notion that Islam is a religion whose adherents have been embroiled in a perpetual state of holy war, or jihad," despite the doctrine itself not being fully fleshed out until the era of religious global conquests long after Muhammad's death (Aslan, 79). On the other side, there are efforts to completely detach jihadist violence from the "true" teachings of the faith altogether. Robert Orsi puts it best in *Between Heaven and Earth*, saying that "the people want to be reassured that the men who flew their planes into the World Trade Center (…) were not representative of "real" or "good" Islam (Orsi, 179). Though they appear to oppose one another, I argue that both positions are driven by a similar impulse to sort religion into moral binaries, while denying the space to engage with its complexities. Disagreement over Islam therefore often reflects a deeper effort to distill the religion into categories that are morally comfortable for observers.

Orsi explains how the American academic culture of religion has historically privileged a certain model of religion—"domesticated Christianity tailored for use in public life"—while casting others as excessive or dangerous (Orsi, 186). It is through this lens that I endeavor to discuss

how Nina Pelikan Straus's psychoanalytic reading of terrorist groups and their actions in her article titled "From Dostoevsky to Al-Qaeda" becomes both valuable and limited. Straus attempts to use literary fiction to fill the gaps of social science in "thinking about the darkest motives of individual lives" (Straus, 198). Her turn to Dostoevsky is effective because literary fiction allows her to explore fantasy as a gateway to understanding terrorism and to resist a purely political or doctrinal explanation on them. However, in her attempt to do so, I argue that she still risks reinscribing Islam as the primary site of eroticized violence and fanaticism, rather than a religious tradition that is granted the same complexity so often afforded to Christianity. This problem becomes even more visible in discussions of women's role in jihadist movements, where the same flawed framework shapes how Muslim women's participation is understood, which in turn made them often legible only through a narrow frame of vulnerability.

Orsi makes it clear that he is not arguing for relativism (Orsi, 180), but rather calls for "the disciplined suspension of the impulse to locate the other (..) securely in relation to one's own cosmos" (Orsi, 198). In the context of jihadist movements, such a method demands to resist the inclination to decide in advance whether these actors represent "real Islam." Instead, it pushes us to ask how religion is being inhabited and mobilized within particular historical and political conditions, while simultaneously interrogating how our own categories of "good" and "bad" religions shape what we are able to see. This does not necessarily mean suspending ethical judgement on violence itself but rather also paying attention to how Islam was made available as an explanatory frame of violence in ways that other religions, like Christianity, often are not.

Straus appropriately identifies that there is something missing from dominant social scientific approaches to terrorism. It is worth mentioning, writing during the thick of the War on Terror, Straus is working within a discursive field in which "Islamic terrorism" is already a politically loaded category. This context matters because at times her essay appears to inherit that broadness of category even when she seeks to complicate the prevailing narrative on terrorism. However, what makes her essay compelling is her insistence that social science cannot fathom the "erotically charged relations" that drive suicide terrorism and turns to Dostoevsky in order to foreground charisma, desire, and power as structures that bind its subject to the continuous cycle of violence.

Yet this is also where the limit of Straus's argument becomes visible. Although she explicitly argues that terrorism should not be reduced simply to religion or politics, Islam still appears as the center stage on which eroticized violence, misogyny, and homosocial bonding appear in their most excessive form. The problem lies in how these dynamics are treated to be especially revealing of jihadism, rather than as features of militarized masculinity and violent movements more broadly. They are also set against a construction of "the West" as a space that has supposedly "labored to get past the identification of murder or self-sacrifice with masculine prowess," which is "not viewed as progress by the Islamist brotherhood" (Straus, 200). The West emerges as comparatively emancipated and self-critical—evident in how advanced it is in the matter of gender—while the brotherhoods are trapped in the archaic conception of masculinity. This echo of cliché civilizational comparison also locates jihadist violence within the narrative of wounded masculinity in relation to the West and therefore "they recruit men to perform violent deeds in expression of fidelity to a culture they see as humiliated—that is, emasculated—by the

West" (Straus, 200). In this sense, Straus does not escape the binary Orsi warns against and, in her pursuit to complicate jihadist violence, she still works within the framework that normalizes the West.

This gendered contrast also has consequences on how women in jihadist movements are understood. When the West is imagined to hold a moral upper hand on gender, then Muslim women who participate in jihad become primarily legible as victims of backwards gender ideology. This logic becomes clear in Straus's treatment of "the woman question." To her credit, she does not reduce women as incidental to jihadist movements and presents the argument that contemporary discourse on terrorism is lacking in "the discussion of women to understanding terrorism properly" (Straus, 199). In her readings of *Demons,* Straus suggests that women are "capable of working through infatuated subordination to independent insight" (Straus, 199), therefore suggesting women in terrorist brotherhood can threaten the false sanctity of its male leaders.

But once again, Straus's seemingly richer discussion remains constrained by her broader framework. The possibility that women might break the cycle of male violence is attached to as specifically "Western, liberal model of male-female relationships" that she sees in Dostoevsky but "absent from Islamist rhetoric" (Straus, 199). This claim on the absence of protests heard from women in jihadist movements freezes them within a narrative of silence and containment, instead of subjects who inhabit and navigate contradictions. Women appear in her account as an essential "victims or instruments" of "homosocial bonding" (Straus, 200). Even when they do act—whether as mothers who name their son Osama or suicide bombers—they "are caught in a

web of contradictions that requires a sophisticated understanding of gender to escape" (Straus, 200). This paper does not seek to deny women of vulnerability nor does it try to claim that women are participating in jihadist movements with full agency. Rather, it asks what happens when vulnerability becomes the dominant frame through which Muslim women can be understood.

To explore the framing of vulnerability of Muslim women, I turn to Lila Abu-Lughod's critique in her notable paper "Do Muslim Women Really Need Saving?" Also writing against the post-9/11 tendency to explain political violence through religion and the treatment of women, Abu-Lughod warns that such framing "prevented the serious exploration of the roots and nature of human suffering in this part of the world" (Abu-Lughod, 784). The saviorism language often carries its own presumptions about superiority and authority. As she puts it, "When you save someone, you imply that you are saving her from something. You are also saving her to something." (Abu-Lughod, 788). This rhetoric of liberation then reproduces what Gayatri Spivak described as "white men saving brown women from brown men" (Abu-Lughod, 784).

Jason Hart's article titled "The Child as Vulnerable Victim: Humanitarianism Constructs Its Object" sharpens this critique further. Hart criticizes when vulnerability is seen as an "universal and undifferentiated property" (Hart, 5) because "it justifies an approach that attributes vulnerability a priori on the basis of categories" which renders further inquiries on the vulnerable subject unnecessary (Hart, 6). Just like how the West portrays children and child soldiers, Muslim women are often categorised as an inherently vulnerable group, and therefore often only visible through victimhood and brainwashing. Hart 's on childrens agency also shed light on how

Muslim women are often recognized as agentive only when their actions align with liberal expectations of resistance. However, where "their actions run counter to those norms, agency is denied or ignored" (Hart, 8). Read alongside Orsi, Hart reveals how this flawed framing is also a problem in the study of religion. Once Muslim women are positioned as vulnerable victims of Islam, their lives are used as a judgement about Islam itself.

All in all, what is at stake in the study of jihadist movements is how Islam itself is approached as an object of knowledge. A better method in studying religion would also yield a better method in studying jihadist movements. It would refuse the false choice between saying jihad is simply the expression of Islam or saying religion is irrelevant to it altogether. Following Robert Orsi's suggestion, such a method would begin by suspending the desire to settle whether these actors are "truly Islam" but would ask instead how religious cause and personal desire, faith and doctrine, agency and vulnerability, historical and political reality, all become entangled in particular forms of violence despite their contradictions. It requires a different analytical attitude: one that rejects moral comfort, refuses civilizational comparison, and resists framing Muslim women in a one dimensional lens of vulnerability. This by no means aims to sanitize violence or absolve groups of responsibility, but to be able to understand and complicate the analysis of violence without reproducing the rhetoric of Islamic exceptionalism.

Generous Acknowledgment

I would like to express my acknowledgement towards everyone in our INTL 488: Thinking on a World Scale capstone class. In particular, I am grateful towards Sheila, Tanguy, and Sam Schafer, for assigning the three readings that played a central role in shaping this paper. I would like to also thank David for designing the leadership assignment and this midterm paper, both were very fun although challenging. I am also truly grateful for Iris, Kai, Hannah, and Carmen for their continuous encouragement throughout the process of writing this paper. Last but not least, thank you to Linh, who—just like back in freshman and sophomore year—never fails to work at the same timeline as me: starting everything last minute. It is comforting to know that some things remain unchanged :)

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